bitter,' said Akbar's letter, 'and this sudden calamity has greatly afflicted my heart.'[26]

A rare example of Akbar's Hindi poetry is a deeply moving couplet for his friend: '*Deen dekhi sab din, ek na dinho dusah dukh, / So ab ham kan din, kachhahun nahin rakhio Birbal.*' (He gave the needy all he had, gave no one ever sorrow /
But now that too he's given me, Birbar kept nothing for his own.)[27]

So upset was Akbar, according to Badauni, that he wouldn't let the two surviving generals, Zain Khan and Abul Fath, into his sight. To those who did gather around him, the emperor mourned the fact that Birbar's body had not been brought back and burned according to the rites the brahmin would have liked. His courtiers tried to comfort him, saying the corpse would be purified by the sun.[28]

Akbar never recovered from the loss of his friend. Years later, when an imposter claiming to be Birbar appeared in Nagarkot, Akbar clutched at the possibility, imagining that Birbar had stayed away all this time, embarrassed by his defeat.

Within weeks of the massacre, Todar Mal had led a vengeful, victorious campaign into Swat and Bajaur. By autumn of that year, another Mughal general called Qasim Khan had led a contingent of troops into Srinagar. Akbar's soldiers had scaled the mountains of the north as they had taken the ports of the west and the rivers of the east. The emperor's gains piled up, unstoppably. But now, in the wake of Bhagwant Das's wounded pride and Birbar's death, so did his losses.

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Two years or so later, in 1589, Akbar lost five of his most trusted and talented mansabdars. The first to go was Tansen, the great singer whom Akbar had poached from Panna decades ago. His death, said Akbar, 'was the annihilation of melody'; and he ordered a fitting tribute.[29] All Akbar's musicians sang and played along Tansen's funeral march. Then, in summer that year, while Akbar was touring his newly conquered territories in Kashmir, the talented astrologer, engineer and staunch Shia, Amir Fathullah Shirazi, succumbed to mismanaged treatment by a doctor. It was only six years since Fathullah joined Akbar's court and, though he had refused to